



Report Date: May 15, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

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TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Manager, Decolonization, Arts and Culture
SUBJECT: Indigenous Community-led Cultural Events – Report Back

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board receive the report on 3-year Corporate Sponsorship Fund support for Indigenous community-led cultural events
- B. THAT the Park Board approve \$50,000 from the Corporate Sponsorship Fund for 2026 to support staff and services for Indigenous community-led cultural events and initiatives in parks

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

In 2022 Park Board approved \$150,000 from the Corporate Sponsorship Fund to support emergent Indigenous community-led cultural ceremony and events in parks. Between 2022-2025, Park Board supported 18 cultural events in parks led by the local Nations and Urban Indigenous organisations.

The Corporate Sponsorship Fund allocation enabled staff to bring funding and operational, technical, and production support to the organization of Indigenous-led cultural events and ceremonies in parks. Staff have documented learnings and developed an ongoing plan to bring sustainable support to Indigenous, community-led work through the Park Board's system after analyzing consistent staffing, infrastructure and financial needs.

The opportunity to do this work is robust, ongoing and contributes immensely to vibrancy in parks. Staff are seeking Board approval for bridge funding for the remainder of 2026 of \$50,000 to continue to support this work.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

- At its meeting of January 11, 2016, the Park Board [adopted eleven reconciliation strategies](#) in response to the Calls to Action provided by the Truth and Reconciliation of Commission. [Park Board Reconciliation Strategies](#) include the direction to:
 - Work with First Nations peoples and other civic bodies to identify, create, and deliver appropriate and actionable staff training on Indigenous issues and Reconciliation;
 - Take a 360 degree approach to programming, including in the areas of culture, health, public dialogue, physical activity, and sport in order to increase public knowledge and awareness of reconciliation and to provide support to Indigenous peoples including children, youth, Elders and families

- Review event permitting and sports hosting opportunities to ensure that Indigenous peoples' territorial protocols are respected and that, if appropriate to the scale of the event, that local Indigenous communities are engaged;
- In April 2018, Park Board received a staff report titled Truth Telling: Indigenous Perspectives on Working with Municipal Governments. The report was a result of a series of consultations led by Park Board staff and Kamala Todd with Aboriginal cultural leaders, artists, and knowledge holders from across Canada, as well as from within the Musqueam, Squamish, and TsleilWaututh Nations. In this report, one of the key messages delivered was that in Canada's journey towards "Truth and Reconciliation", the critical step of truth-telling must come first. [Truth-Telling: Indigenous Perspectives on Working with Municipal Governments](#)
- On April 16, 2018, the Board adopted the [Reconciliation Mission, Vision, and Values](#) as a foundation for Reconciliation within the organization. The mission—to decolonize the Park Board—is an ambitious one, and has reframed much of the ongoing regular business of the Park Board, as well as internal staff cross-departmental relations.
- On October 19, 2020, the Park Board approved the [VanPlay Framework](#), for Vancouver's [Parks and Recreation Services Master Plan](#). The VanPlay [Playbook](#) directs Park Board to "focus reconciliation efforts on decolonizing the Park Board and relationship building with the Musqueam, Squamish, and Tsleil-Waututh Nations".
 - G.6.1 Instill the Mission, Vision and Values of Park Board Reconciliation and Decolonisation into the Park Board's organisational culture of learning, respect and truth telling.
 - G.6.6 Ensure partnership agreements and consulting procurements reflect the Truth and Reconciliation Commission's calls to action and Park Board's Reconciliation and Decolonization values.
 - G.8.4 Create funding mechanisms to support community arts and artists-in-residence that are focused on relationships between Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples.
 - G.8.5 Provide clear decision-making guidance for cultural development, decolonisation, expression in parks, prioritisation of intangible cultural heritage and promotion of cultural redress
 - F.2.2 Develop a robust culture of welcome, inclusion, anti-oppression, and truth and reconciliation within the Park Board.
- [\\$150,000 Corporate Sponsorship Fund for Indigenous-led Community Events \(2022\)](#)
On July 18, 2022 Park Board approved a contribution of \$150,000 from the Corporate Sponsorship Fund to support the delivery of emergent cultural events led by Indigenous Organizations and Community for 3 years.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Between 2022 and 2025, Park Board supported 18 cultural events in Parks that were led by the local Nations and Urban Indigenous organizations with a financial investment of \$150K resourcing Park Board staff and event support. Park Board staff from Arts, Reconciliation and Culture (ARC), Recreation, Urban Forestry, Operations and Filming and Special Events (FASE) supported a range of Indigenous cultural practices focused on land-based healing, ceremony, celebration,

community gathering and cultural sharing. Examples of community-led events that Park Board supported in 2022 – 2025 include:

May 2022	Squamish Mask Ceremony at Xway Xway
April 2023-ongoing	MMIMB2S (Murdered and Missing Indigenous Men, Boys and 2 Spirit individuals Memorial March & Canoe Launch
July 2023	Squamish Nation <i>Return to Seḥákw Celebration</i>
Aug 2023 & 2024	Circles Indigenous Music Festival
June 2024	Indigenous People's Day Movie Night in Stanley Park
July 2024-ongoing	Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-wututh Community Days in sṭəqəlxenəm ts'exwts'áxwi7 Park
Sept 2025	Tsleil-Waututh Nation Community Day at Xway Xway
Sept 2025	Kilala Lelum Dream Canoe Launch, Truth and Reconciliation Day

The events ranged from small community gatherings to major festivals. Funding allocation broke down into 6 broad categories with additional in-kind staff support beyond the Corporate Sponsorship Fund resourcing.

From 2022 through 2025, costs included:

Site Operating Supplies and Equipment	\$ 60,750
Traffic Control	\$ 5,250
Catering	\$ 20,075
VPD/Security	\$ 22,300
Staff Hours	\$ 39,225
Permits	\$ 2,400
Total	\$150,000

Additional in-kind staff support: \$20,000

Through the Corporate Sponsorship Fund allocation, Park Board staff provided financial support for aspects of this work when the requirements of our system exceeded the capacity of the event organizers. This included funding for permits, risk management, policing costs, traffic management and events operating supplies and equipment. Each project was unique and requirements were determined on a case-by-case basis. Staff focused on “going the extra mile” to enable safe, well-resourced Indigenous-led events to happen in parks without placing an additional burden of work on the local Nations and Indigenous community in order for them to host gatherings on land now stewarded by Park Board. These factors were outlined in the pilot proposal and have remained consistent.

Staff roles and responsibilities included developing partnerships and facilitating relationship building between local Nations staff teams and Indigenous community groups and Park Board staff teams/members, as well as third party contractors connected to Park Board. Staff provided internal operational, technical and facilitation support to reduce barriers to cultural work on the land. Organizational capacity for the Nations and other groups is often stretched, so timelines for this work were sometimes short.

DISCUSSION

Developing the Park Board's ability to enable Indigenous community-led work is an organizational priority. Staff have developed a sustainable approach for 'flexible consistency,' remaining responsive to the needs of unique events and projects. Our experience with this work has shown that relationships and capacity evolve over time as Park Board support enables capacity building for Indigenous organisations and groups.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

This complex work is not currently funded through any Park Board service group. While the size and number of event requests fluctuate annually, analysis of the event cycle over three years predicts that an investment of \$50,000 annually would support an event cycle similar to what we experienced from 2022 to 2025. To complete the work for 2026, a withdrawal from the Corporate Sponsorship Fund would ensure service continuity until the 2027 operating budget is determined.

The Park Board's policy on the approved use of the Corporate Sponsorship Fund (CSF) was developed in 1998 and includes the following use criteria:

- a. To fund one-time expenditures to a limit of \$50,000 that will support revenue-generating activities and the money repaid into the Corporate Sponsorship Account from the increased revenues within a period of three years.
- b. To fund initiatives with one-time expenditures to a limit of \$50,000 that will result in improved efficiencies.
- c. To fund one-time expenditures over and above the existing funding levels in the operating budget which are beneficial to the overall Parks and Recreation system.

The recommendation within this report aligns with Criteria C. All contributions from the CSF require Board approval.

While this program has received funding once from the CSF, given the importance of this ongoing work to our Reconciliation Mandate and the ongoing work growing positive relationships with the local Nations and Urban Indigenous Community, staff is asking for the Board to approve CSF bridge funding for 2026.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

This work has provided invaluable opportunities for staff education and increased understanding of Indigenous cultural practice and the work of supporting Reconciliation in our system, in community and on the land. We are grateful to the local Nations and to Indigenous artists, cultural practitioners, organizers and communities for their patience and generosity as we learn how to best support their work.

As discussed in the pilot proposal for this work, Park Board staff are challenged to bring a flexibility, humanity, and collaboration to addressing the requirements and restrictions of working in our system without engaging in practices that cause harm to Indigenous communities and organizations. Staff engage with the responsibility of a complex burden of work to support communities rather than placing that burden of work on Indigenous community in order for them to work with us.

This work exemplifies interdepartmental staff collaboration, involving nearly every team in our system: Arts, Reconciliation and Culture; Recreation; Operations and Trades; Special Events and Filming; and Park Planning & Development all work together to enable Indigenous community-led events.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

Arts, Reconciliation and Culture staff will continue to play a leadership and support role in this cross-departmental work with the support of consistent funding.

Park Board has the increasing opportunity to support Indigenous community-led projects, events and ceremonies in parks. This work is important to both the relationship building that is foundational to our Reconciliation Mission and Mandate and our commitments to Reconciliation articulated in VanPlay.

Park Board staff are seeking Board approval for bridge funding of \$50,000 from the Corporate Sponsorship Fund for 2026 to support Staff and Services for Indigenous Community-led cultural events and initiatives in Parks until a consistent operational funding model fund can be integrated into the annual operational budget to support this work with secure funding and appropriate staff resourcing moving forward in 2027.

Park Board staff have carefully considered the various aspects of this request and recommend that the Board approve this application as outlined above. Three years of facilitation and documentation have taught us that Indigenous Communities and organizations are ready to bring ceremony, events and projects to parks and often, a small amount of funding and staff support can be the deciding factor enabling the work to go forward. Relationships of trust have been enabled over the last three years through this work and staff support risk of harm to community, relationships and reputation should the work not continue. Finally, this small investment of funds will bring huge benefit to increasing vibrancy in parks. ARC is committed to furthering this work and to reporting annually to the Board on its progress.

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